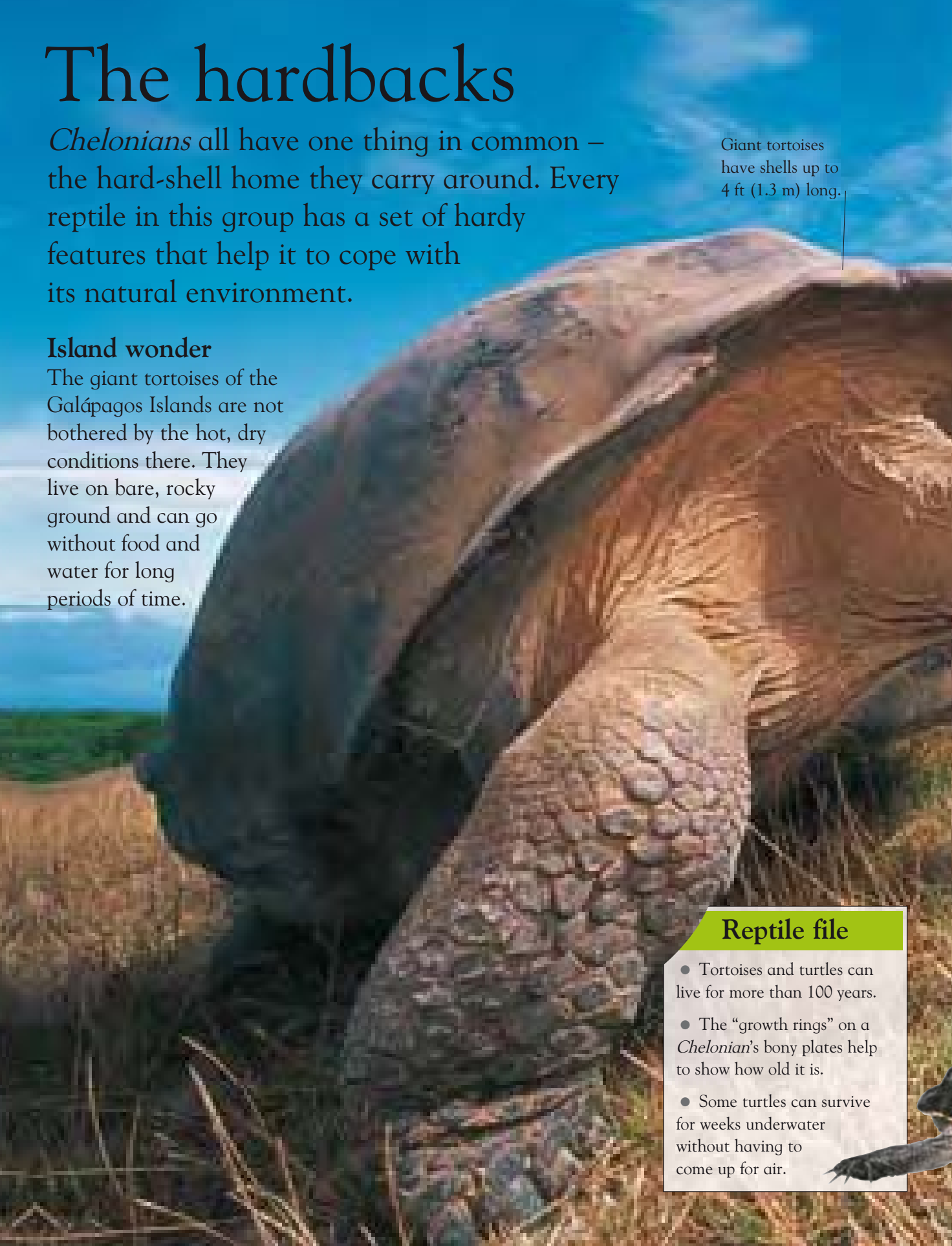
The hardbacks

Chelonians all have one thing in common – the hard-shell home they carry around. Every reptile in this group has a set of hardy features that help it to cope with its natural environment.



Giant tortoises have shells up to 4 ft (1.3 m) long.

Island wonder

The giant tortoises of the Galápagos Islands are not bothered by the hot, dry conditions there. They live on bare, rocky ground and can go without food and water for long periods of time.

Reptile file

- Tortoises and turtles can live for more than 100 years.
- The "growth rings" on a *Chelonian*'s bony plates help to show how old it is.
- Some turtles can survive for weeks underwater without having to come up for air.